a padayatra, stirring up head winds for Yadav. The trigger: on June 23, huts were taken down within Kheoni sanctuary, Dewas. It's not as if its owners were left homeless. The 51 evicted families are residents of Kheoni Khurd village, just outside Kheoni sanctuary; 49 have pucca houses under the PM Awas Yojana. In 2015, they had begun farming on forest land.

But there's a wider story that seems to have caught Chouhan's eye. The Kheoni sanctuary management has asked for 6,000 hectares of forest to be added to its existing 13,400-ha. footprint. Also, in 2019, the Congress regime had proposed that the Ichhawar range, in adjoining Sehore district, be rebirthed as the Sardar Patel Sanctuary (SPS). The prime mover: then forest minister, present LoP, tribal and Congress leader Umang Singhar. The Sehore Divisional Forest Officer (DFO), acting on orders, had begun the preparatory steps. So, many locals feared suspension of residential rights.

On June 29, Sehore saw agitations. Raising its pitch, Chouhan led a delegation to meet the CM. Calling the BJP a party sworn to tribal welfare, Chouhan called pause on SPS and prevailed on Yadav to transfer Sehore DFO Magan Singh Dabar (a tribal himself). On July 5, Chouhan was in his element, trawling through Kheoni Khurd in lashing rain on foot and by tractor. "Some officials have become insensitive. How would they feel if their children are left out in the open in rains?" he declaimed.



Kheoni, with 10 tigers, is formally tagged as a promising sanctuary. The Ratapani reserve, 100 km away, has 60-plus tigers. SPS would have linked both habitats. But of the state's 9.4 million ha forest land, 1.1 mha. have encroachments (Vidisha has the worst figures). Save 350,000 ha. given away as pattas, this can be reclaimed; 12,000 ha. was, before monsoons. The squatters at Kheoni are mostly Bhil, Bhilala and Barela tribals, non-native settlers there, like those in Sehore et al. But they have a vote. The tiger does not. ■

Takeaways

- **51 squatter families evicted from Kheoni sanctuary on June 23**
- **Ex-CM Chouhan leads tribal protests as plans for new Kheoni sanctuary spike fears over residential rights**
- **CM Yadav has signed off on two new tiger reserves and one wildlife sanctuary**
- **Tussle between Chouhan and Yadav seen as a growing rift in the state BJP**

▶ ASSAM

THE COWS THAT NEVER CAME HOME

An ambitious dairy project curdles into an embarrassing scandal, as state BJP brass are shown to have vamoosed with prize Gir cows

By **Nandita Borah** *and* **Achintya Patangia**

IT WAS IN THE CRUEL SUMMER OF 2021, amidst the second wave of Covid-19, that the bulldozers arrived in Gorukhuti. Encroached land, they called it. By the time the dust settled on this corner of Assam's Darrang district, hundreds of families—mostly Bangla-speaking Muslims of suspect citizenship—had lost their homes. On the cleared land was to be sown an ambitious promise: the Gorukhuti Bahumukhi Krishi Prakalpa (GBKP), a model project for indigenous farmers. Chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma painted a vision of agricultural renaissance rising from the ruins of displacement. Three years later, that vision has curdled into scandal.

One centrepiece of the project: Gir cows, famed for their milk production, would be imported from Gujarat to zip up Assam's dairy sector. At least that

CHEW IT OVER Opposition Congress leads a 'cow protest' against the Gorukhuti project scam

